

Architectural Analysis of Freeplane – Reverse Engineering and Evaluation

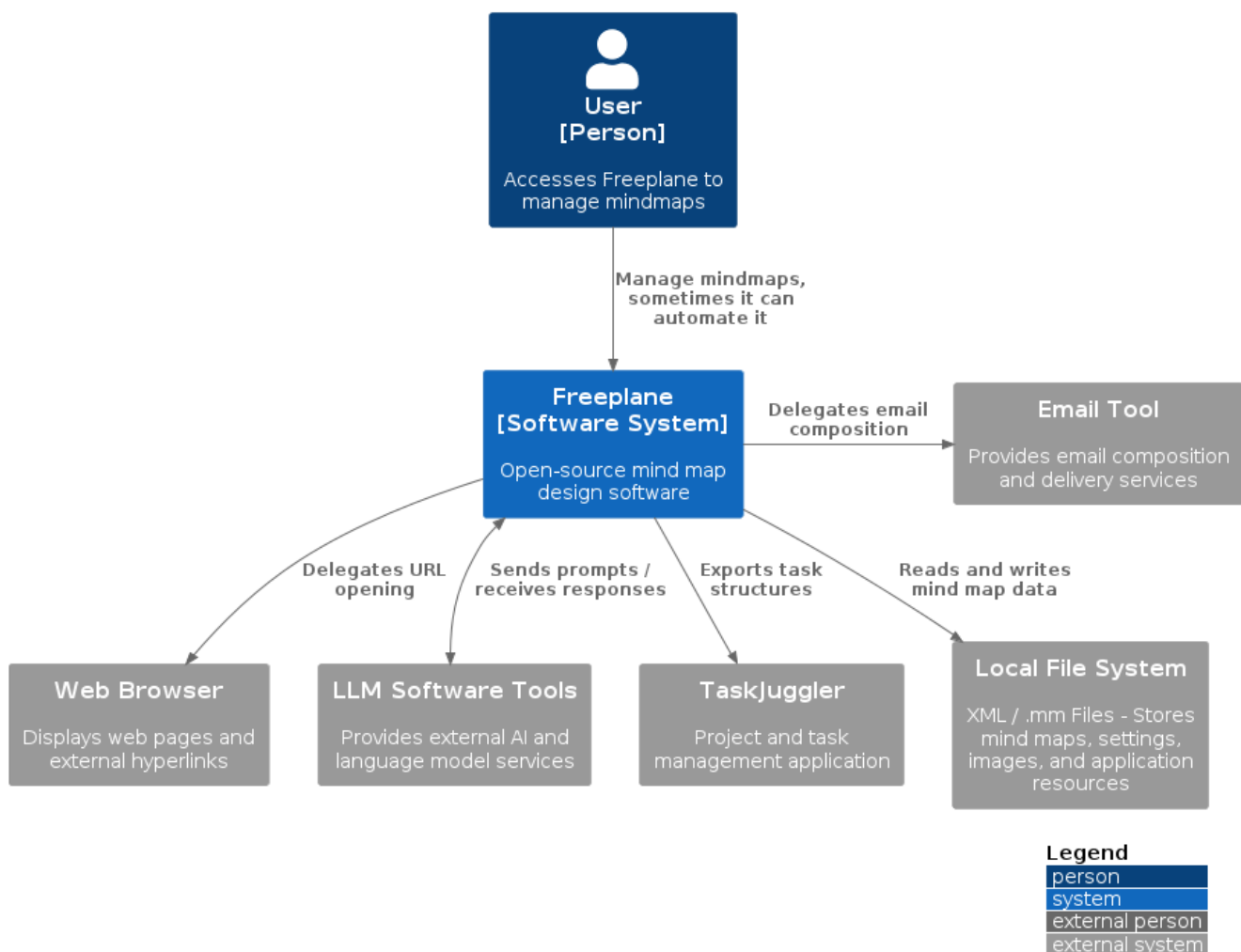
Introduction and Analysis Methodology

This report presents an architectural analysis of the Freeplane mind-mapping software, reverse-engineered via static code analysis, documentation review, and repository statistics. Architecturally, it is an imperfect micro-kernel monolith based on the OSGi framework. The core module implements business logic, while plugins extend functionalities. This design breaks strict micro-kernel principles, hence the imperfect definition.

The System in its Ecosystem: C4 Context Model

Freeplane was born as a fork of the well-known Freemind software. The official documentation reports that the decision was taken to improve software's design and to speed up its development and maintenance cycles.

Freeplane Software Context Diagram



Although represented as a single actor, users can be distinguished in two groups: basic users, who use Freeplane for standard mind mapping, and advanced users, who write custom Groovy scripts to extend its features. Freeplane also supports a GUI-less execution mode accessible from the terminal, which advanced users may exploit. Nevertheless, these groups have been merged into a single Actor since they all share the same system entry point — the distinction is behavioral, not structural, and therefore not relevant at the architectural level.

The first type of external interaction is direct data persistence: the persistence layer is delegated to the Operating

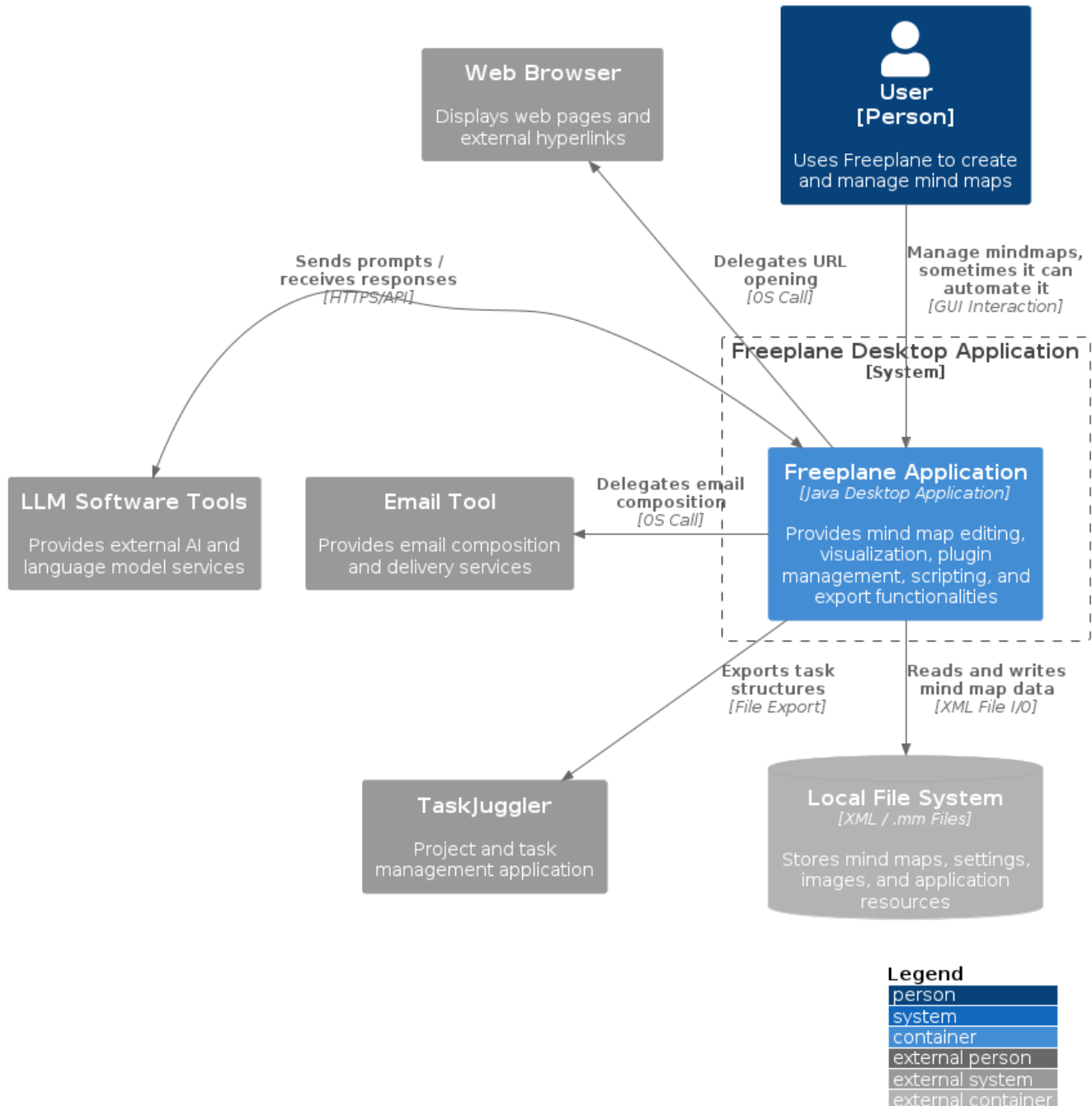
System via standard file I/O. Two more types of interaction with external systems can be identified: - Task delegation: the system depends on external tools that are responsible for handling operations outside its own scope. The relationships with the Browser or with the Email tool fall into this category — clicking a URL or clicking an email address triggers actions that Freeplane delegates entirely to the appropriate external system. - Data delegation: the dependency involves an active exchange of information. The integration with TaskJuggler requires Freeplane to transform and adapt the content of a mind map into a structured set of tasks before transferring it to the external system. This is a unidirectional relationship. The interaction with LLM systems also falls into this category, but the relationship is bidirectional: sending a prompt transfers data to the LLM API, which in turn sends information back through its response.

The tension between different kinds of dependencies reveals that the software has grown over the years to support different features to meet requirements that can be very different among users.

Decomposition and Runtime: C4 Container Model

The Container Model aims at showing how the software is built, from a lower, more detailed standpoint.

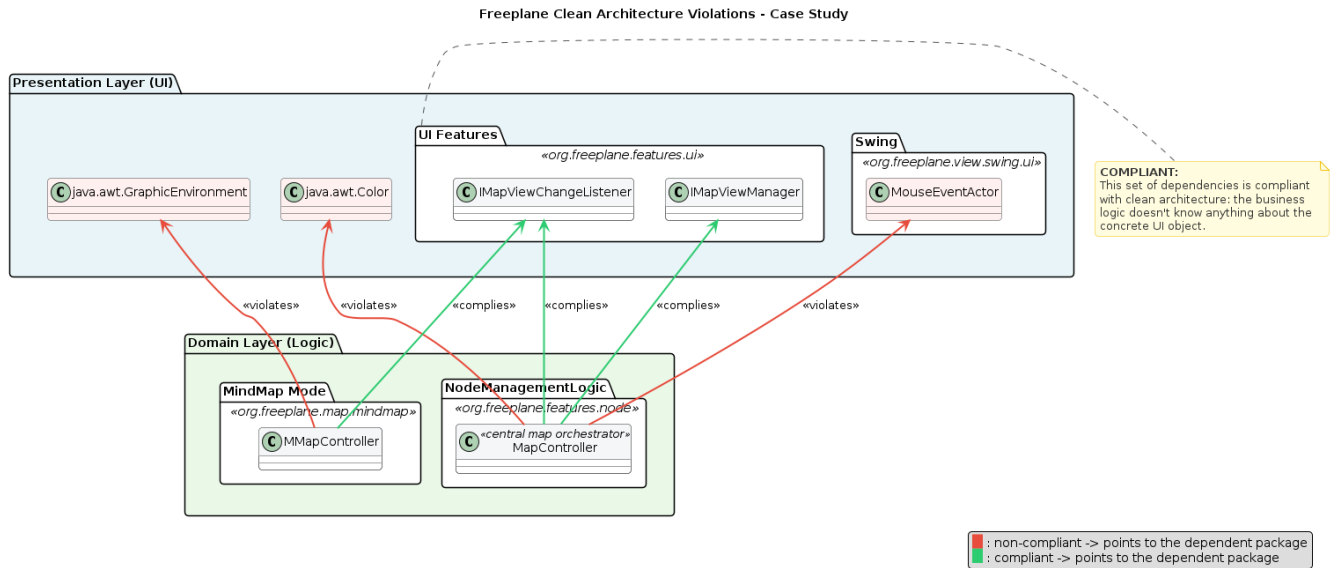
Freeplane Container Diagram



Freeplane is represented as a single Container due to its OSGi-based architecture. Plugins (bundles) are developed separately and are mutually isolated, but depend on the OSGi engine to run: they have no autonomous lifecycle outside the core. Plugins such as freeplane script or freeplane latex extend core application features and cannot operate independently. Furthermore, bundle startup is managed sequentially by a kernel instantiated in the freeplane core package launcher, making it impossible to run them outside that environment. For these reasons, the lack of independent deployability rules out classifying plugins as separate Containers. The persistence layer is delegated to the Operating System. Freeplane stores information related to the single mind-map in a proprietary file format, that is the **.mm**. This is an XML-derived format, that fits the definition of mindmaps as nested blocks of nodes. Users can independently decide where to save files. This implies less overhead related to internal persistence layer management.

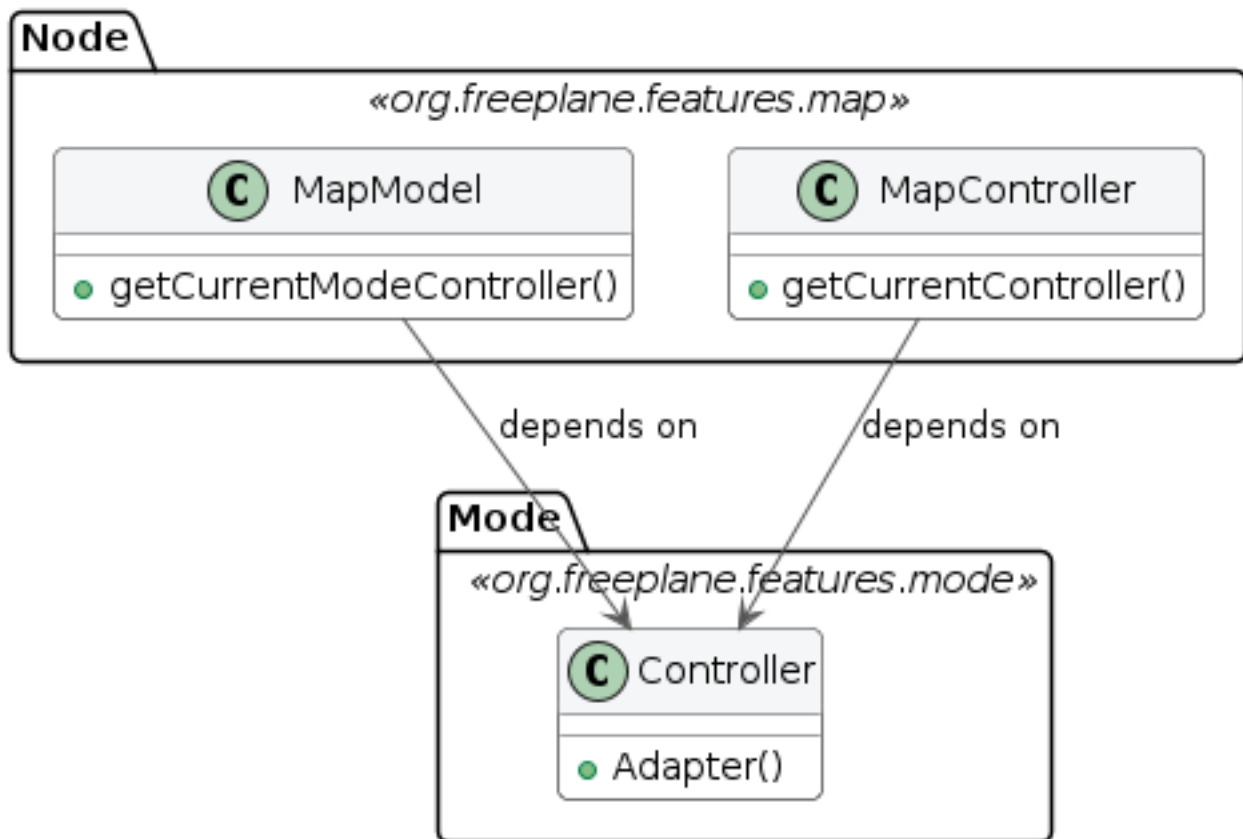
Mapping to Clean Architecture This section evaluates Freeplane’s compliance with Clean Architecture principles by analyzing its core package, `org.freeplane.features.map`. Repository mining reveals this package is highly unstable due to tight coupling with UI components. Specifically, almost 43% of its commits involve co-changes with the frontend—peaking at 61% for subpackages like `org.freeplane.features.map.filemode` and `org.freeplane.features.map.clipboard`.

Dependencies involve both custom Freeplane UI classes and standard Java AWT ones. There is a mixed approach: classes often import Interfaces from the `org.freeplane.features.ui` package, that represent the abstraction for the User Interface management. However, sometimes there is direct interaction with frontend classes: for instance, class `MapController` manages map view through the `IMapViewManager` interface, but it implements a concrete method for managing an external peripheral (the mouse, through `MouseEventActor`). Many concrete standard Java UI classes are imported as well. This mixed approach results in high-coupling between the business logic and external layers in the architecture, making it less isolated and more difficult to be tested and extended or modified.

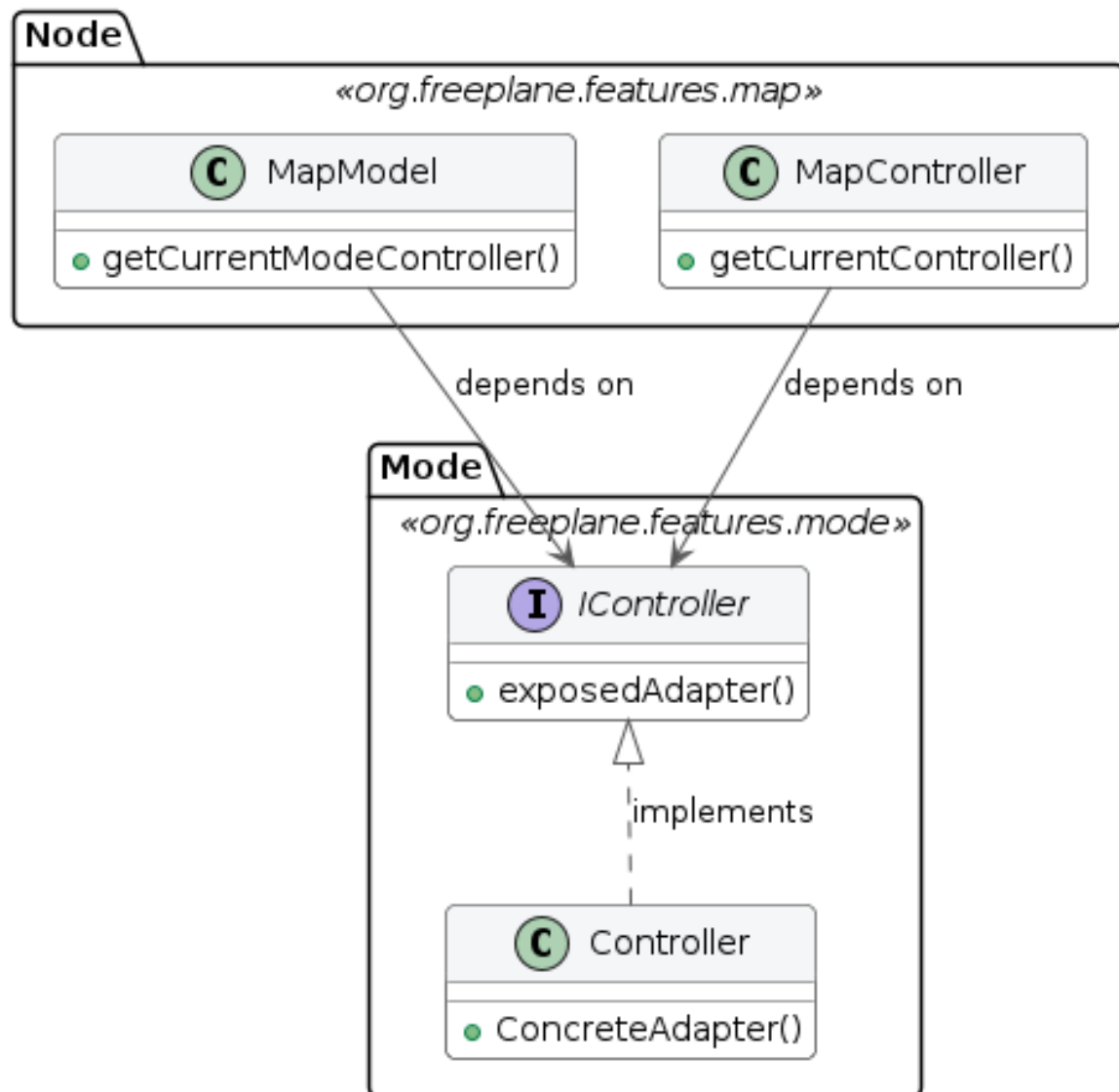


There are other crucial violations of the Clean Architecture pattern: there is no clear definition of *entities*, *use cases* and other layers. Some classes may look similar to one of these concepts: `MapModel` could be classified as an *entity*, `MapController` as a *use case*, `Controller` from `org.freeplane.features.mode` as an *adapter*. Most critical violations of the Clean Architecture pattern can be found in the dependency among these three classes: `MapModel` and `MapController` depend on the `Controller`; the flow of dependencies is broken and therefore inner business logic cannot be tested in isolation.

Class Diagram: Dependency Violation



Class Diagram: Dependency Violation - Possible refactor solution



Compliance with the principles from the Clean Architecture pattern can be found in the *persistence layer*: classes such as **MapReader** and **MapWriter** are at the outer layer of the architecture, and there are no dependency violations. They perform operations to save or read data from the mindmap directly in the `.mm` file. The `org.freeplane.features.filter` package suffers from the same set of problems: its **FilterController** has the same mixed approach at User Interface import dependencies, and it mixes business logic, application logic, and frontend concerns in the same class. That's why architectural flaws from `org.freeplane.features.map` package can be fairly extended to the whole software structure.

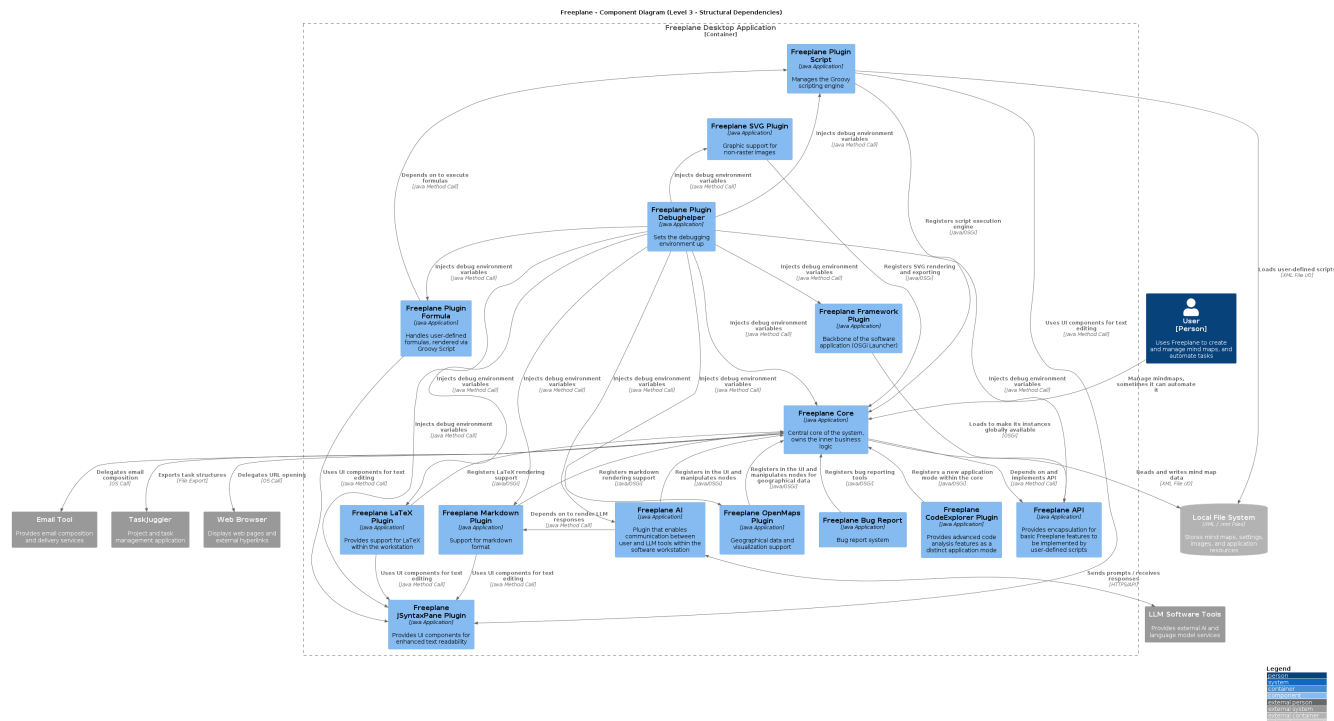
Boundary analysis on the same packages confirm these architectural flaws: frequent Common Closure Principle (CCP) violations are evident. Classes often co-change unnecessarily, primarily involving **MapController** and the **Swing** library. This indicates loose boundaries and problematic coupling between business entities and UI components. Conversely, core business classes like **MapModel** and **NodeModel** lack static dependencies and rarely co-change, showing good isolation at the entity level. Consequently, `org.freeplane.features.map` acts as a generic, low-cohesion container. While violating strict Clean Architecture principles, a looser, pragmatic separation of concerns still exists within the package.

To sum up, the software does not fully comply with Clean Architecture principles. There are many violations that mainly concern architectural boundaries: the most serious violation is the lack of clear division between entities and

use cases, and the broken dependency flow. Dependency on concrete User Interface methods makes the software more difficult to be tested in isolation. These violations have an explanation: as reported in the Official Documentation, core classes were designed to be extensible, and to follow the Extension-Object Design Pattern defined by Erich Gamma. This architectural choice aims at building extensions to well-defined objects. The lack of compliance with the Clean Architecture can be explained by the need to have both entities and use cases in the same set of classes to make them easily extensible. However, Extensible Object theory does not justify the direct implementation of UI elements in core entities. This remains a pure violation of the Separation of Concerns at an architectural level.

Zooming into the Engine: C4 Component Model of the Core

The Component Model offers the deepest view of Freeplane’s internal structure, detailing how the single container introduced in Section 3 decomposes into individually deployable OSGi bundles and the external libraries they depend upon.



The diagram reveals a layered hierarchy that governs how the system bootstraps and how data flows between components.

Framework Plugin. The Framework Plugin sits at the top of the dependency tree. It initializes the OSGi runtime, loads the API plugin, making its instances globally available to every downstream bundle, and wires the entire component graph together.

Freeplane Core. Directly below, the Core owns the inner business logic — map models, node structures, mode controllers, event dispatching — and delegates work (scripting, rendering, SVG export, error reporting) to downstream plugins. It also interacts with several external systems. The examples are: Opening URLs in the **Web Browser**, redirecting to the **Email Tool**, and exporting tasks to **TaskJuggler**. The MVC triad lives here: **MapModel** and **NodeModel** define the domain entities, while **MapController** and **ModeController** orchestrate user actions. However, controllers like **MapController** aggregate some concerns (I/O setup, action registration, navigation, folding) in a single class, pointing to **SRP** pressure. The same pattern recurs in **FilterController** and **ModeController**. The pervasive use of **Controller.getCurrentController()** — a concrete singleton — and similar patterns in **MapWriter** also indicate a **DIP** concern, coupling components to concrete implementations rather than abstractions.

API and Lateral Plugins. The API exposes core features for user-defined Groovy scripts. Alongside it sit four lateral plugins: AI, OpenMaps, CodeExplorer, and Bug Report. Notably, three of them also call *upward* into the Core to register UI elements, creating bidirectional dependencies managed at runtime through OSGi. The AI plugin in turn relies on **LLM Software Tools** for prompt/response exchanges. In this layer,

`NodeLevelConditionController.createASelectableCondition()` uses `if-chains` to select condition types — an **OCP** concern — while the `filter.condition` subpackage applies a Strategy/Decorator pattern that is fully OCP-compliant, showing inconsistent application of the principle.

Script Engine and Dependent Plugins. The Plugin Script component manages Groovy and resolves dependencies via Apache Ivy. Formula, Markdown, LaTeX, and JSyntaxPane all build on it. JSyntaxPane additionally cross-cuts Markdown and LaTeX by providing graphical text-rendering features to both. At this level, `SingleCopySource` extends `NodeModel` but throws `RuntimeException` for inherited methods, raising a **LSP** concern. `IMapSelection` bundles many responsibilities into a single interface (**ISP** concern), while `INodeChangeListener` offers a clean, minimal counterexample.

SVG Plugin. Handles image rendering via Apache Batik and PDF transcoding via Apache FOP.

Cross-Cutting: Debug Helper. The Debug Helper injects debug environment variables into every other component, touching all layers without belonging to any single one.

These SOLID concerns are not confined to `org.freeplane.features.map` — they recur across the Core, reinforcing the assessment from Section 4 that business logic, application logic, and UI concerns are insufficiently separated.

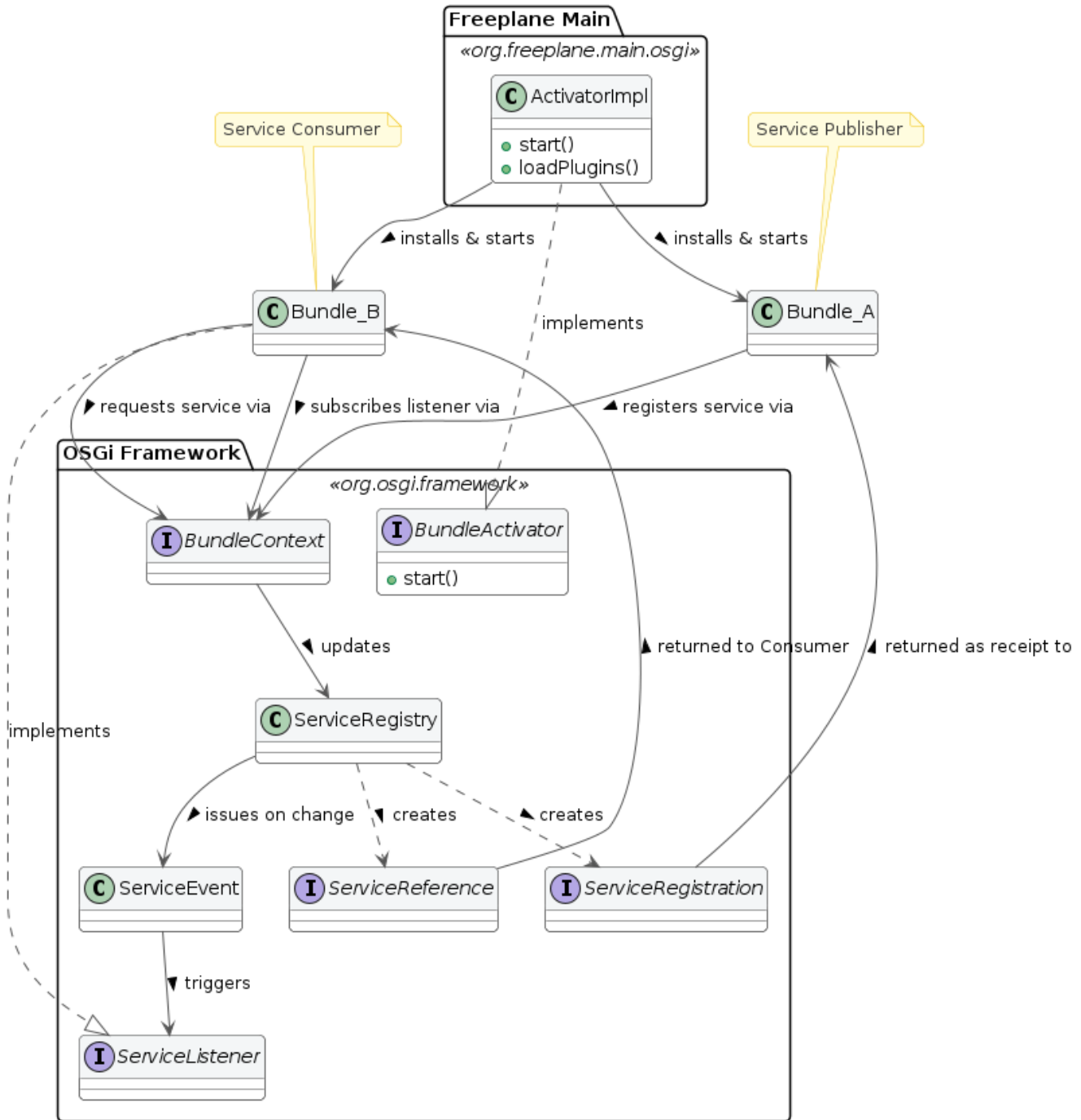
Architectural Characteristics and Conclusions

Boundaries: Core-Plugin interaction analysis

Freeplane is built on top of the OSGi framework, in the Knopflerfish implementation. This technology stack allowed developers to build a modular software, where different plugins can be attached to the core easily. The framework generates a three-layer hierarchy: 1. Module Layer: it is the declarative layer: it defines bundles identity and static dependencies. In Freeplane, the `org.freeplane.core` package plays this role. This piece of information can be easily understood by reading its `MANIFEST.MF` file when compiled: it stores all settings and dependencies for building the application. 2. Activator: it is responsible for building the infrastructure to make plugins communicate. In Freeplane, it is the `ActivatorImpl` class in `org.freeplane.main.osgi`. It can be identified since it implements the `org.osgi.framework.BundleActivator` class. 3. Service Layer: bundles provide services, that are registered within the Framework exploiting mechanisms that are built in OSGi environment. Such services can be published or unpublished at anytime. They look like plain Java Objects.

The OSGi bundles are built to be independent: there is no shared knowledge, code or data, and all references to classes or methods in other plugins throw OSGi errors. Plugins and Core have therefore strict boundaries, crossed by pointing to published services only. At the Module Layer, circular dependencies can lead to deadlock: thread 1 starts Bundle 1 requiring a service from Bundle 2 and stops until it is published; thread 2 starts Bundle 2 requiring a service from Bundle 1 and stops. This can be solved by implementing additional features provided by the framework. Freeplane resolves these dependencies at runtime through a single Activator responsible for building the application and attaching plugins. On the other hand, at the Service Layer, a clear dependency tree cannot be drawn, since bundles both publish and exploit services from other bundles, which will likely require services from further plugins. Dependencies are resolved at runtime, making the flow of information across bundles harder to track and debugging more difficult.

OSGi and Freeplane



This structure provides both freedom and constraints to developers: new features can be added by creating a new dedicated plugin. Moreover, since bundles are independent and well separated, deployment and maintenance does not affect the overall system. Caveats of this architectural choice are the programming language and the complete compliance to the framework: developers must write all plugins in Java (the OSGi framework doesn't support other programming languages), and they must write plugins that implement the logic described above.

Conclusions Freeplane balances extensibility and legacy constraints. Its OSGi plugin system and Extension Object Pattern provide robust, two-level extensibility. However, the core suffers from systemic architectural debt: God Object controllers, pervasive singleton dependencies, and the business logic layer coupled to AWT/Swing. These issues, rooted in the software's 2009 origins, make the core untestable in isolation and resistant to UI migration.